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Will God Answer My Prayer?

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Will God Answer My Prayer?

You do not have, because you do not ask God. When you ask, you do not receive, because you ask with wrong motives, that you may spend what you get on your pleasures. (James 4:2-3)

Have you ever prayed really expecting God to answer, or do you just say the words because you know you should? If you prayed for rain, would you carry an umbrella expecting to use it? Can you quickly list how God has answered prayer in your life this week? Maybe you haven't had an answer to prayer lately and you wonder...why doesn't God answer my prayers?

Prayer is simply sitting and talking with God face to face. It's a conversation. It doesn't take big fancy words or a special voice, just words from your heart. Some of the best prayers in the world are the prayers of children because they just say what they want and don't worry about how it sounds to anyone else. Prayer is how we get to know God better. It is the same as building a relationship with a friend. The more time you spend in conversation, the closer you become and the more you know about the other person.

God gives us some straightforward directions about our prayer life in His Word. James tells us that if we do not come to God and ask in prayer, He can't answer it. Many times prayer is our last resort after first going to friends or trying to figure it out ourselves. James also gives us another reason for unanswered prayer...wrong motives. If our prayer is simply to gain something for our own pleasure, God tells us that is a wrong motive.

John 15:7 says, *"If you remain in me and my words remain in you, ask whatever you wish, and it will be given you."*

We see in this verse the key to answered prayer...remaining close to God and keeping his commandments. That will help us understand how to pray in a way that will be answered.

1 Thessalonians 5:16-18 also gives us helpful instruction for praying. *"Be joyful always; pray continually; give thanks in all circumstances, for this is God's will for you in Christ Jesus."*

This is a clear statement of God's will for our lives. He wants us to always be joyful, pray continuously, and be able to give Him thanks in all of our circumstances. If we truly understand God's love and caretaking of us, we can be joyful all the time. We will pray continuously because we will believe He hears and answers prayer. Ultimately we will be able to be thankful in any circumstance because we know He is in control and has what is best for us in mind.

Take some time to think through the commands in this verse. Are you joyful? Do you pray throughout your day giving things over to God? Can you give thanks to Him knowing He has full control and will take care of things so you can relax? This really is God's will for you in Christ Jesus.